On My Own

By Mary Krell-Oishi

NATHAN: Today was the one-year anniversary of my dad's funeral. I loved him and I know he loved me. But I hardly knew him. I've been pretty much on my own since I was a kid. Not that I'm that old now, but I'm sure not a kid. Dad was a lawyer. Criminal defense. He was pretty good, I guess, because people were always calling the house to get him to defend their low-life relatives from some crime they were accused of. I couldn't understand how he could do that, but he said if we are to have justice in this country, then everyone has a right to a fair trial, both the guilty and the innocent. Yeah, I guess, but how fair is it when someone who is guilty walks free? He could never explain that part of it.

INTRODUCTION

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NATHAN: Dad was one of a kind. Really smart, star athlete, school government, everything I want to be, but doubt I will. My mom says I'm just as good as Dad. I guess so. Everything I know about my dad I learned from my mom. Dad was never one for talking. At least not to me. Oh, I always knew he loved me, but I wasn't sure he liked me. I feel kind of strange saying that, but that's how I feel. He was always in court or a law library or meeting with a client or something. I honestly don't remember him coming to a game or a concert or anything I did at school. Mom was always telling me that he wanted to be there, but work and all...1 don't know. It always seemed to me

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that if he really wanted to be there, he would. Mom came. Not all the time, but most of the time. She works, too. She teaches, so she's off during summer and vacations, but she always has papers to grade and tests to prepare and all that kind of stuff. She used to get mad at Dad sometimes, though, when I had a football game or something and he couldn't be there. One time I remember them arguing about it. But you know, it was really no big deal to me. I was used to him not being there, so you know, so what, right?

There was a time when I was little that I used to get mad about looking up into the stands at, say a Little League game. He, of course, would tell me he would try to be there. Like a jerk, I'd spend the whole game watching the stands instead of the field hoping I'd see him. One time - and this is really dumb - one time I looked up and I thought I saw him. I was so excited, you know? Then it was my turn to bat and I knew I was going to hit that ball out of the park. So I lined myself up at the plate, took my practice swing, and then waited. The pitcher threw the ball. Strike one! I wasn't worried. I knew I was going to nail the ball. The pitch and strike two! OK, now I started to get worried. I looked up and saw those sunglasses he always wore, shining there. I thought I heard him call out to me. I was so happy. I had to hit the ball out of the park for him, make him proud, make him want to come to all my games. I looked at that pitcher and inside I dared him to try to strike me out. Dared him! Well, he looked me dead in the eyes, wound up, and fired a pitch so fast all it was to me was a blur. I swung hard and heard a big "crack." I'll be damned if I didn't hit the hell out of the ball. I stood there and watched it go into this beautiful high arch and fly like it had wings right out of the field. I figured the only one more surprised and happier than me

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at that moment would be my dad. The coach yelled at me to circle the bases, and I did. You'll never have a greater feeling than running the bases after a home run! As I rounded third to home, I looked up and waved at my dad. But he wasn't watching me. He had taken off his glasses to clean them. That's when I saw it wasn't him. The only home run I ever hit and he wasn't there. He had promised that for sure, this time, he'd be at that game. But he wasn't. No one from my family was there. When I got home, Mom told me she had a student conference, and when Dad finally got home, at about nine o'clock, he apologized and said he had to meet with a client being held for murder. So it goes, right? I didn't even tell them about the home run. I mean, what was the point? It wasn't like they had planned to not be there just to make me unhappy. They both had to be at their jobs and that was important. That was the last year I played Little League. It just didn't seem all that important, you know?

I spent a lot of time playing really cool video games when I was home alone. I wasn't allowed to go outside or have anyone in the house if my parents weren't home. That was OK...I mean I understood it because they wanted me safe. But it was kind of a drag to have to come straight home from school and stay in the house until they got home. Everyone else would hang out at school and play basketball or something, but I had to be home. After awhile, though, that got old, so I started staying at school and hanging out with my friends until right before Mom would get home. See, school was out at two forty-five for me, and three o'clock for her. But she always had to stay after and work with kids. She was the on-site math tutor, so she never really left school until about four-thirty, then it took her about half an hour to get home, so I was on my own until five o'clock. I didn't do bad things. Can't do

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much bad in less than two hours. One time, though, my friends and I went to the mall and got our ears pierced. Neither of my parents noticed for about two weeks. By the time they did I just told them that I had done it months earlier and all the kids did it. What was cool was my dad noticed it first about eleven o'clock at night. He said something, then my mom came in and they had a discussion about it, but it was late and they were tired, so by the time they were done talking about it, they just told me it was my ear and I could do what I thought was right. The funny thing is, though, I was kind of hoping they'd get mad and tell me to take it out. My friend Glenn got his ear pierced that same day. He got home and his parents noticed it right away. Boy, were they mad. They grounded him for a week. I gave him a hard time about it. But you know what? I was jealous. I wished my parents had paid enough attention to get mad at me about it. Hell, I wish they had just noticed that I had done it. jeez, it sounds like my parents are bad. But they're not. Or weren't. Whoa, Dad's gone. Wow. Dad has passed away. He's not with us. Dad is dead. Anyway you say it doesn't make it better. He died really dumb, too. Not even something that he'd be proud he died of, like saving someone from a burning building or pushing a child out from in front of an oncoming car. Nope, he died choking. He was running late to an appointment with one of his criminals and stopped to get some chicken at a fast-food place. He did what he always did, which was eat in the car in the parking lot. He would never eat while he drove, because he said it was unsafe and he didn't want to cause an accident. But he choked on a chicken bone. And he was alone. Alone with a bone. I can almost guarantee you that his last thought wasn't of me and my mom. His last thought had to be, "Well, this is dumb."

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So, Dad's been gone a year. In some ways I miss him. I don't miss money, because he had a great insurance plan and savings and stuff, so financially we're OK. And it's not like I miss him at the dinner table, because he was never really there for dinner. In fact, I don't think I can really remember ever sitting down and having dinner at an appointed time. Glenn gets in huge trouble if he's not home by six-thirty. Dinner is on the table and everyone better be there or there is hell to pay. I eat there a lot. It's gotten to be a kind of joke with his family, because they just automatically set a place for me at dinner. No, it's weird. I don't really miss my dad, because I was used to him never being around. When he was alive I could always have the hope that he would show up for a game. I could dream that some day he would put me first over one of the criminals and actually show up for something when he said he'd show up. When Dad was alive I could hope that some day, maybe some day, we'd sit down and have that father/son stuff going on. I figured it would probably happen when I grew up. But now it won't. I'm going to grow up and Dad won't be there. You know what's really scary, though? I can't remember what he looked like. Oh, we have pictures and stuff. But I look at them and I can't remember him being there in person. I look at those pictures and see a stranger.

I tried to talk to my mom about it all. Not easy. At first she was pretty shook up. But after a few months, she settled back into her job. She's working on her Ph.D. in education because she wants to be an administrator. I guess that's good. Whatever, huh? She's dating. My mom has dates. More dates than me. What does that tell you about my social life. What kind of bothers me, though, is that she can suddenly find the time to date, because before she and Dad couldn't find the time to be together as a family. Does

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anyone see the irony in that besides me?

So, like I said, I'm pretty much on my own. I have a car now, and Mom has let up on the be-home-no-one-in-the house stuff, which is good, because I wasn't doing it anyway. She never knew, so so what. So, I go to school, keep my grades up, and hang out at the mall with my friends and do sports. I think I've done a helluva job raising myself. I'm a good kid. But I feel lonely sometimes. I go home to our big old house and hear my footsteps echo on the stairs. I make myself dinner and do my homework. I'd play with a dog if I had one, but Dad was allergic and Mom said dogs were dirty, so I lost out there. I go out with my friends and try to beat Mom home. She has late-night classes at the university. And don't forget her dates. Anyway, I take care of me.

It hasn't been all that easy being on my own, especially when you look around and see friends that have parents who are there for everything. But other people have it worse than me. At least my parents stayed together and tried to make sure I had everything I needed. But it would have been nice to have them there, you know?

So, Dad's been dead a year. I don't miss him, really. He wasn't around that much to miss. And I'm not mad at him. I mean, he worked hard to be a good lawyer and he had to work hard to stay at the top. What I miss is the idea of a dad. I go to the cemetery sometimes. To be honest, I go to the cemetery more than Mom. I sit by his grave and talk to him, tell him what's going on in my life. I ask for his advice and if I'm really quiet and listen really hard, sometimes I feel he answers me. I didn't feel this close to him

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when he was alive. One thing I remember, though, is when I'd be asleep. I was usually in bed before he got home from work. I remember hearing him open the door and I'd open my eyes so that he'd know I was still awake. I could see the light beam through the crack of the door. Then Dad would come in and sit on the bed for a minute and pat my back and mess up my hair. He'd say, "Good night, Natty." He never called me Nathan unless he was mad; it was always Natty. Hey, that was one really good thing about him not being around when my friends were around - they couldn't hear him call me Natty. Anyway, I remember his hand on my hair, and his good night and I would pat his leg and tell him I loved him. And now, sometimes when I talk to him at the cemetery, the wind will blow, just a little bit. Just enough to mess up my hair. If I really listen, 1 can hear him say, "Good night, Natty." I put my hand on his grave and I whisper, "I love you, Dad"

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Mary Krell-Oishi
Book: Perspectives: Relevant Scenes for Teens
ISBN: 1566080304
Publisher: Merriwether Publishing, Ltd
Date(Month/Year): March 1997

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